

CHALLENGE ACCEPTED

The Ultimate Fighting Championship (UFC) looks set for an **eventful** first quarter as we head into the new year.

UFC 311 Makhachev vs Tsarukyan

The first numbered event of the new year boasts a stacked main card, headlined by the lightweight title fight between reigning champion Islam Makhachev of Russia and Georgia's Arman Tsarukyan.

Tsarukyan, who made his UFC debut in April 2019, has become one of the most talked about grapplers, with an impressive record of nine wins in 10 fights, including four finishes. Interestingly, life comes full circle for the surging fighter as he takes on a familiar foe. Tsarukyan's introduction to the UFC world did not go as he would have liked. The reason? His next opponent, Makhachev.

The 28-year-old has lost just twice in his UFC career, and the first of those losses was to the very same Makhachev, who is currently on a 14-fight win streak.

It ended in a unanimous decision in favour of Makhachev, but Tsarukyan did not go down without a fight. The 15-minute contest was one of the most technical displays from both fighters. Tsarukyan had a response to every takedown that Makhachev threw at him, but it came down to the officials' discretion, who ruled it in the Russian's favour. But that's the beauty of time — it changes things. Tsarukyan has evolved by leaps and bounds to become the monster he is today. If statistics are to be taken seriously, then Makhachev might actually have a worthy opponent in Tsarukyan.



Pics: GETTY IMAGES

UFC 311 Dvalishvili vs Nurmagomedov

Umar Nurmagomedov will finally get his much-deserved chance at the belt this January. Last November, he expressed his frustration with fighters not stepping forward to face him. "I'll fight anyone the UFC offers me because I want to be the best," he posted on X.

Fast-forward to January 2025, and not only will he step into the octagon, but he will also have a shot at the bantamweight title when he faces Merab Dvalishvili at UFC 311.

Dvalishvili claimed UFC gold last September, dethroning Sean O'Malley at UFC 306. The Georgian currently rides an 11-fight win streak, with standout performances against numerous former champions, including Henry Cejudo, Jose Aldo, and Petr Yan.

The Machine faces one of his toughest tests in Nurmagomedov, who boasts an 18-0 record as a professional. Nurmagomedov is coming off a dominant unanimous decision victory over Cory Sandhagen.

